INTRODUCTION: THE FALL OF AN EMPIRE

Since his salvation from the ice at the end of Marvel's ***Captain America: The First Avenger,*** Steve Rogers has been a man out of time. His convictions, rivaled only by his strategic prowess, are the foundation of what makes Captain America a great hero and the Avengers' fearless leader. As we, the audience, have watched Captain America evolve through the events in the Marvel Cinematic Universe, Cap has watched the world around him change—rapidly. Steve Rogers is no stranger to war. Consequently, he understands the nature of sacrifice, as well as the unwelcome truth of war's casualties. And he understands the inevitability of collateral damage: an alien invasion in ***Marvel's The Avengers*** that practically leveled New York; a Dark Elf attack in Marvel's ***Thor: The Dark World*** that almost wiped out the human race; the reveal in Marvel's ***Captain America: The Winter Soldier*** that Hydra had infiltrated S.H.I.E.L.D. and was planning to kill millions; and finally an entire city lifted into the air—and dropped just after evacuation—in Marvel's ***Avengers: Age of Ultron.***

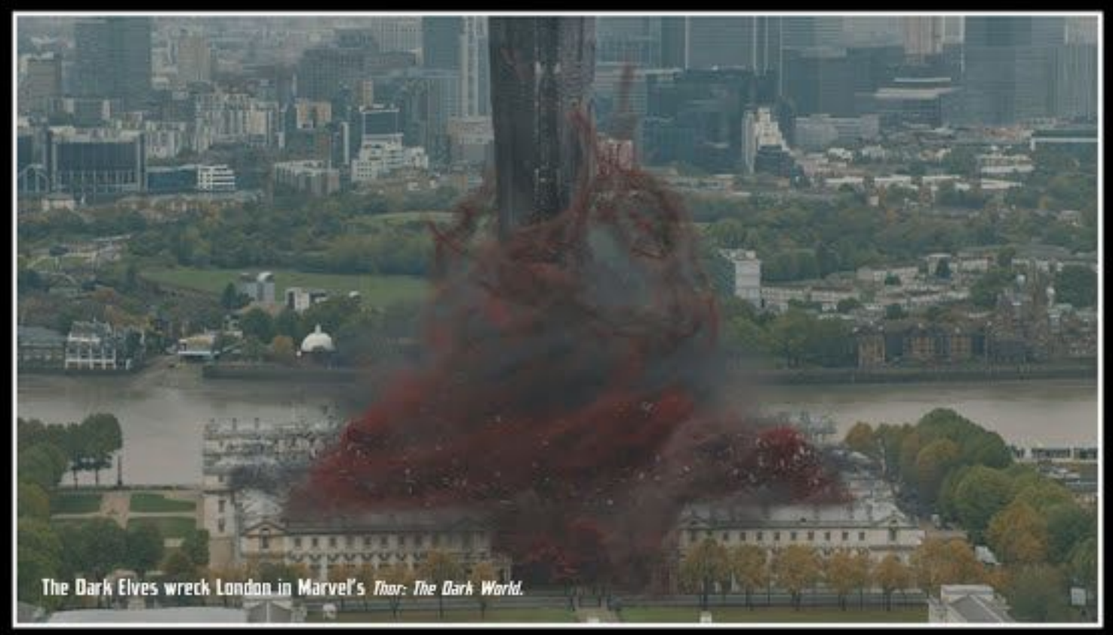
According to Marvel Studios President Kevin Feige, all of these events—along with Steve Rogers and Tony Stark's differing headstrong ideals—are the basis from which Marvel's ***Captain America: Civil War*** stems. "It's a Captain America film, it's the third film in the Captain America trilogy, but it also is a film that has a very important place amongst all of the other films that we've made, in particular the other Avengers films. By this point, people know Steve Rogers very, very well. People know Tony Stark very, very well. And we felt it was time to see them [in conflict], because we know their personalities so well—we know how they work together, and we know that they have some issues with each other. They're very, very different people. How would they react if they were faced with an issue that they just disagreed about?

"There's an amazing storyline from the comics called ***Civil War,*** which is one of the best miniseries that Publishing has produced since I've been at Marvel (for 15 years), and in it there is an event that occurs that causes the governments of the world to say, 'We need to have oversight over these heroes now.' In our story that 'oversight' is basically because of the collateral damage caused during all of the action sequences of the other films." While the ***Civil War*** comic-book series, written by Mark Millar and illustrated by Steve McNiven, revolves around the Superhuman Registration Act, the central conflict in both the film and comics lies in the characters' choices.

At the onset of the film, William Hurt's Thaddeus "Thunderbolt" Ross, last seen in Marvel's ***The Incredible Hulk,*** returns as secretary of state. He arrives at the Avengers Facility with an ultimatum in the form of the Sokovia Accords: Allow the United Nations to oversee the Avengers' future endeavors—or be arrested for acting as vigilantes. "Tony Stark surprisingly agrees with this, and he thinks if it helps the world sleep better at night, this is something we need to do—and we actually have no choice, because if we don't allow this to occur, we're not going to be able to operate the way we want to, and we won't be able to do the kind of things [we need] to save the world," Feige explains. "Steve Rogers, on the other hand, says, 'Well, I've worked for authority figures before. I remember when the World Security Council sent a nuclear bomb—against Nick Fury's wishes—to New York City that we had to stop. I remember when the organization I signed up with, S.H.I.E.L.D., turned out to in fact be an evil organization, Hydra, that I thought I had defeated in World War II. Why do we think it's a good idea to have an authority figure?' There's some people that agree with Steve, and there's some people that agree with Tony, and that becomes the fundamental disagreement between them



The Chitauri invade New York City in *Marvel's The Avengers.*



The Dark Elves wreck London in Marvel's *Thor: The Dark World.*